He stood to one side and watched me put on my red name tag, WALES, then sign in. He told reporters how proud he was.

Then extended his hand. *Off you go, darling boy.*

Photo op. Click.

I was assigned to a platoon of twenty-nine young men and women. Early the next day, after pulling on our new combats, we filed into an ancient room, hundreds of years old. You could smell the history—it seemed to come off the wood-paneled walls like steam. We recited an oath to the Queen. *I swear allegiance to Crown and country…*The lad beside me shot an elbow into my ribs. *Bet you say Granny rather than Queen!*

That was the last time, for the next five weeks, that he or anyone else would venture a joke. There was nothing funny about boot camp.

Boot camp—such a benign name for what happened. We were pushed to our limits, physically, mentally, spiritually. We were taken—or dragged—to a place beyond our limits, and then a bit further, by a stolid group of lovable sadists called color sergeants. Large, loud, extremely masculine men—and yet they all had tiny little dogs. I've never heard or read an explanation for this, and I can't venture one. I'll only say that it was odd to see these testosterone-rich, mostly bald ogres cooing at their poodles, shih tzus and pugs.

I'd say they treated us like dogs, except they treated their dogs so much better. With us they never said: *There's a good boy!* They got up in our faces, shouted at us through the clouds of their aftershave, and never, ever let up. They belittled us, harassed us, shrieked at us, and made no secret of their intent. They meant to break us.

If they couldn't break us, brilliant. Welcome to the Army! If they could, even better. Better to know now. Better that *they* should break us than the enemy.

They used a variety of approaches. Physical duress, psychological intimidation—and humor? I remember one color sergeant pulling me aside. *Mr. Wales, I was on guard one day at Windsor Castle, wearing my bearskin, and along came a boy who kicked gravel on my boots! And that boy…was YOU!*

He was joking, but I wasn't sure I should laugh, and I wasn't sure it was true. I didn't recognize him, and I certainly didn't remember kicking gravel on any guardsmen. But if it *was* true, I apologized and hoped we could put it behind us.

Within two weeks several cadets had tapped out. We woke to find their beds made, their stuff gone. No one thought less of them. This shit wasn't for